Introduction

The history of Israel begins with the ancient Hebrews, who settled in the region known as Canaan in the Southern Levant around 1200 BCE. They formed a united monarchy under biblical figures like King Saul, David, and Solomon before splitting into the northern Kingdom of Israel and the southern Kingdom of Judah. Both kingdoms faced exile—first the northern kingdom to the Assyrians, and later Judah was conquered by the Babylonians.

In the sixth century BCE, the Persians, under Cyrus the Great, allowed the Jews to return and rebuild the Second Temple in Jerusalem. However, Roman rule then began about 500 years later, leading to the destruction of the Second Temple and the Jewish Diaspora, which saw Israelites exiled and dispersed across the Roman Empire and the rest of the world. Subsequently, different empires, such as the Byzantine and Ottoman Empires, controlled the region, with Jewish communities often being a minority.

The idea of re-establishing a permanent Jewish homeland in the Middle East first emerged in the nineteenth century. As early as 1839, Sir Moses Haim Montefiore, a successful British banker, petitioned the ruler of Egypt, Mohamed Sa'id Pasha, to consider setting aside some of his land to create a Jewish state in the region called Palestine. Although the proposal was rejected, it marked one of the earliest instances when the idea of establishing a Jewish state in Palestine was put forward. By the time that World War I began in 1914, this concept was being widely discussed. In Britain in 1917, the foreign secretary, Arthur Balfour, wrote to Lord Rothschild, a leading member of the Jewish community in Britain, noting that the British government supported "the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people."

After the war was over, the League of Nations awarded Britain the right to rule territories in the Middle East previously controlled by the Ottoman Empire. British possessions under the terms of this agreement included what was by that time called Mandatory Palestine, located in the Southern Levant and bordering Egypt, Transjordan, Syria, and Lebanon. Given British pledges, many Jewish people assumed that this meant that the creation of a homeland was imminent. Instead, Britain backed down in the face of intense opposition from neighboring Arab nations.